



New framework planning – Support needs assessment

This fact sheet explains how disability support needs will be assessed in the National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS) from April 2027.



What is a support needs assessment?

A support needs assessment is a guided conversation between a NDIS participant and a trained, accredited NDIA assessor. It's used to understand a participant's disability support needs.

It was recommended by the NDIS Review to create a more consistent and person-centred approach to NDIS planning and funding decisions.

The assessment gathers information about a participant's daily life, goals and support needs to help determine their reasonable and necessary supports and plan budget.

This process is based on NDIS Rules that:

- set out how assessments will be done
- the assessment tools that can be used
- how these tools will work to identify disability related support needs
- what must be included in a support needs assessment report, and
- when a replacement assessment may be needed.

This information will be used to determine funding for NDIS support groups.

When does this start?

Participants will start transitioning to new framework planning from April 2027. NDIS participants will be contacted ahead of moving to a new framework plan. They will receive information and be supported as they move to the new way of planning.

NDIS participants who have not yet received a Notice of Impairment will also begin receiving these from 1 February 2027. A Notice of Impairment outlines the impairment categories a participant meets to access the NDIS. More information is available [here](#).

What makes up a Support Needs Assessment?

A support needs assessment is made up of four parts:

Core Needs Assessment

- Assesses a participant's core disability support needs.
- Results are recorded in the NDIS Needs Assessment Tool.

Personal and Environmental Circumstances Questionnaire (PECQ)

- Collects additional information about a participant's personal circumstances and environment.
- Questions will be asked about living arrangements, informal supports, education and employment, and assistive technology and home modifications.
- Helps identify additional individual needs.

Targeted Assessments

- Used for participants where more detailed assessment of complex needs is required.
- Draws on evidence from health and allied health professionals.

Instructions to assessors

- To make sure all participants have a fair and consistent experience.
- Used by all NDIA Assessors to translate information from the core needs assessment, PECQ and targeted assessments into a description of a participant's disability support needs.

What happens during the assessment?

A NDIA Assessor will meet with a participant to understand their daily life, disability-related support needs and NDIS plan preferences. Participants can bring a support person to this meeting, such as their nominee, family member or advocate.

The NDIA Assessor will check the information they gather with the participant and their support person (if they have one attending) to make sure it is correct.

The support needs assessment report

The results of the assessment will be recorded in a support needs assessment report (the report). This report is reviewed by a NDIA delegate to make sure it includes all the required information.

Participants will then receive a copy of their report. They can also choose to share it with a nominee, family member or advocate. If a participant has concerns about the report, the NDIA delegate will discuss these with them and consider whether a new assessment is needed.

The report must include information about the participant's disability-related support needs, as well as any other important information identified during the support needs assessment.

The report must be provided to the NDIA delegate as soon as possible after the assessment is completed. It is used to help inform the participant's reasonable and necessary budget and new NDIS plan, in line with the NDIS legislation.

The report is currently being designed by the NDIA in consultation with participants and the disability community to make sure it's clear and useful. An example of what the report may look like can be found on our [Consultation Hub](#). The NDIA is also conducting workshops, forums and testing activities to make sure the report reflects the experiences and needs of people with disability and includes the information required by the NDIS legislation.

How does the support needs assessment work with the NDIS plan and budget?

A support needs assessment is a guided conversation used to understand a participant's disability-related support needs. A trained and accredited NDIA assessor will discuss different areas of the participant's life, including daily activities, goals and the supports they need.

The assessor records information about what the participant can do, what support they require, and how often that support is needed. Information about support provided by family, friends, community services and paid supports is also considered.

The information gathered is used to create a support needs assessment report. The report provides information about the participant's disability-related support needs, goals and circumstances. It also includes information from the PECQ and targeted assessment modules that are used. These help identify any additional support needs, such as home modifications and assistive technology.

The support needs assessment report is used to inform a participant's NDIS funding. Information in the report is considered against the NDIS budget method rules to help determine a participant's reasonable and necessary budget for their NDIS plan. [More information about budgets is here.](#)

How this works in practice

Thanh is a 26-year-old woman who lives independently and has a physical impairment. She receives a Notice of Impairment that confirms she has physical impairments eligible for NDIS support and is invited to book a support needs assessment. Before the assessment, Thanh gathers any recent information from her occupational therapist (OT) and GP, including that her wheelchair is more than eight years old, no longer fits properly and requires frequent repairs. During the assessment, Thanh talks with the assessor about her daily life, disability-related support needs and goals.

The assessor uses this information, along with supporting evidence from Thanh's OT, to complete the support needs assessment report and confirms her need for a replacement wheelchair. The report is then used to inform her NDIS funding based on the budget method rules. A plan delegate considers the assessment findings, Thanh's support needs and her experience and preference for self-managing funding and approves a five-year plan with self-managed funding. The delegate also explains the next steps for obtaining a new wheelchair and discusses how Thanh can use her flexible budget to support her independence and achieve her goals.